

Portrait Guide #014

Difficulty Advanced

Est. time 10-14 hours

Subject 6-month old baby girl

Pencils Prismacolor Premier

• COLOR PALETTE



Nectar

PC1092

Dominant warm peachy-tan base tone; core skin color establishing warmth and infant luminosity



Beige Sienna

PC1080

Warm tan accent for form modeling; mid-tone transitional on cheeks and nose



Pink Rose

PC1018

Cheek and lip saturation; warm reflected light; optical mixer for natural flush



Clay Rose

PC1017

Cool-tinted rose undertone; subtle shadow transitional; optical mixing layer



Lavender

PC934

Cool shadow undertone; optical mixing in shadow zones; subtle under-nose glaze



Tuscan Red

PC937

Dark warm red-brown; hair depth; facial shadow accent; iris modeling



Dark Umber

PC947

Deepest dark; pupil definition; upper lash line sharpness; value anchoring



20% Cool Grey

PC1060

Cool shadow planes; eye socket subtle depth; sclera undertone; cool glaze in receiving shadows



10% Warm Grey

PC1050

Very light highlights; sclera base; subtle shadow undertone on neck; peak light accents



Ginger Root

PC1084

Warm transitional mid-tone; nose side modeling; hair base shadow; cheek form



Peach

PC939

Warm highlight on nose tip and cheeks; subsurface scattering glow; light layer optical mixer



Salmon Pink

PC1001

Warm reflected light; cheek and lip saturation; subsurface scattering accent



Peach Beige

PC1085

Light warm accent; delicate highlight layer; forehead and cheekbone peak assist



10% French Grey

PC1068

Neutral light blending pencil; garment base; subtle shadow undertone; unifying glaze



Cloud Blue

PC1023

Cool garment shadow modeling; subtle eye undertone; cool reflected light on neck



White

PC938

Eye highlights (specular point); burnishing final pass; peak light accents on forehead and nose



Cream

PC914

Light burnishing; warm final highlight burnish; soft peak light on cheekbones



50% French Grey

PC1072

Blending tool for edge softening; transitional mid-tone; subtle shadow unification

• VISUAL ANALYSIS

SUBJECT IDENTIFICATION

What is the subject?

A 6-month-old infant girl with delicate, rounded facial features; soft expression; large, alert eyes; sparse, fine, light-colored hair; and warm medium-toned skin carrying the peachy, golden undertones characteristic of healthy infant skin.

Material characteristics

Infant skin is thin, translucent, and highly reflective of subsurface scattering; the skin carries visible circulation (cheeks, ears, nose tip glow warm); hair is wispy and fine, catching light as individual filaments rather than a dense mass; eyes are proportionally large and carry natural specular highlights from moist tissue.

Geometric structure

Infant head is roughly circular/oval with soft, underdeveloped bone structure; the eye sockets are large and the orbital region is more prominent than in older children; the jawline is minimal and rounded (no angular definition); the nose is small and rounded; the ears are delicate and semi-transparent; the head-to-body ratio is large (typical for 6 months old).

LIGHT & SHADOW ANALYSIS

Light source direction

Soft, diffuse frontal key light (likely window light, diffused studio setup, or open shade outdoors); light is even and frontal, creating minimal harsh shadows and no pronounced directional modeling.

HIGHLIGHT

Forehead apex (top center), bridge and tip of nose, cheekbone peaks, upper eyelids (caught light); these zones read at the lightest value and carry warm, peachy highlights.

LIGHT AREA

Entire front-facing side of the head; cheeks and face are fully illuminated with no prominent shadow planes; the lit areas carry warm peachy-tan and golden undertones.

MIDTONE

Cheeks (the rounded form), sides of the nose, forward-facing jaw; these areas establish form through gentle value shifts within the warm color family; transition zones between lit and shadow.

SHADOW

Upper eyelids (cast shadow from lid onto iris); gentle shadow under the nose; minimal core shadow on the away-side cheek (if head is slightly angled); subtle shadow zones on the underside of chin and under the jaw (self-shadow of the rounded form).

CAST SHADOW

Soft shadow cast by the head and chin onto the neck and upper garment; this shadow reads cool and very subtle, barely visible against the warm skin and light garment.

Edge quality notes

All edges read soft and integrated due to the soft, diffuse light and the delicate, rounded forms of an infant face; there are no sharp terminator lines or hard planar breaks; the eye is the exception—the upper lash line reads as the single sharpest, most defined edge in the entire drawing (focal point); the iris edge is soft; the sclera boundary is lost into the surrounding skin; the hair-to-forehead edge is soft and wispy; the jawline into neck is a gradual, lost edge; the garment-to-skin edge is soft and integrated with subtle reflected light bounce.

COLOR ANALYSIS

Overall temperature

Warm golden-peachy. The dominant skin tone carries a warm, golden undertone characteristic of healthy infant skin under warm or neutral daylight; cool tones are reserved for shadows and undertones, never dominating the overall read.

Light zone tendency

Warm and light. The lit side of the face leans toward peach, salmon, and warm tan (PC1092 Nectar, PC1080 Beige Sienna, PC939 Peach, PC1001 Salmon Pink); highlights push toward cream and pale yellow-peach; the cheeks and nose tip intensify toward rose-pink and warm peach, emphasizing subsurface scattering.

Shadow zone tendency

Cool-shifted but warm-weighted. Shadow areas (eye socket, under nose, gentle away-side cheek) shift toward cool undertones (PC934 Lavender, PC1060 20% Cool Grey, PC1017 Clay Rose) but remain warmer and less desaturated than typical adult shadows; infant shadows read as subtle, warm-tinted transitions rather than cool, grey zones.

Special color areas

Nose tip and cheeks: intensely warm and slightly saturated (subsurface scattering effect); ears: semi-transparent with warm peachy glow on lit side and cool undertone on shadow side; eyes:

irises carry warm-to-cool gradient (warm yellows and peaches in lit zone, cool blues and purples in shadow zone under lid); lips: pale and delicate, upper lip cooler and desaturated, lower lip lighter and warmer (light-catching surface); hair: sparse and light, rendered as individual fine strokes in warm and cool browns (not as a solid mass).

Saturation distribution

Saturation is highest at the blood-rich zones (cheeks, ears, nose tip, lips) and decreases toward the outer features (forehead, jaw); the most saturated areas are the cheeks and lips (warm pinks and roses), establishing the natural infant flush; the least saturated areas are the deepest shadows (which shift cool toward blue-violet) and the transition zones (which read as mid-saturation warm tans).

• STEP-BY-STEP INSTRUCTIONS

01 Step 1: Value Structure Block-In (Light Monochrome Foundation)

Entire face, neck, and visible head—establishing complete value range

Light-pressure circular strokes and directional hatching, following the contours of the face; establish a value map without filling any area densely; treat this as a light understructure, not a finished drawing.

Light pressure

Before adding color, establish the structural foundation by mapping the complete value range (highlight, midtone, core shadow, reflected light) using a warm dark pencil at very light pressure. The eye reads form primarily from value separation, not from local color accuracy, so this monochromatic pass is critical—skip it, and the face will read flat regardless of color choices. Using PC947 Dark Umber at light-to-medium pressure, place value anchors: the darkest pupil zones (the eyes are the deepest darks in the portrait), a gentle core shadow on the cheekbone if the head is angled, and a whisper of shadow under the nose and along the eye socket. Work across the entire face evenly at light pressure, avoiding heavy blocking; this preserves paper tooth for the many color layers to come. For soft, frontal infant lighting, keep all values relatively compressed (no harsh hollows or dramatic shadows), but maintain gentle depth between lit and shadow zones to establish that the form turns in space, not lies flat.

COLORS ● PC947 Dark Umber

✦ *Light pressure now = luminous skin later. If you press hard in this foundation phase, you crush the paper tooth and lock yourself into a compressed value range—the drawing will read flat and dull no matter how many colors you layer over it. Infants especially need delicate handling throughout; press as if you're making contact with tissue paper, not canvas. The temptation is to 'establish darks quickly' with heavy pressure—resist it. Speed will trap you; light pressure is the long view.*

02 Step 2: Establish Eye Pupils, Iris Sphere, and Cast Shadow (Depth Structure)

Both eyes—pupils, iris, upper eyelid shadow cast onto the eyeball

Place the pupil as a small, precise dark circle; layer the cast shadow as a soft, graduated tone that wraps the upper iris; add the warm red undertone as a thin glaze in the lower iris; define the upper lash line as the single crisp dark edge.

Light to Medium pressure

The eye's three-dimensionality depends on the cast shadow from the upper lid falling across the iris sphere. Place the pupil (a small, dark circle) with PC947 Dark Umber at light-to-medium pressure, then add a soft shadow wrapping from the upper lid across the upper half of the iris—this shadow reads slightly cooler and indicates that the eye is a sphere, not a flat disc. The cast shadow edge should be soft and diffuse on the lower iris (where reflected light from the lower lid bounces back onto the sphere) and slightly crisper at the upper edge where the lid edge catches more light. Add a touch of warm PC924 Crimson Red into the lower iris to begin modeling the sphere and suggest the warm blood-vessel glow that makes eyes read alive. The upper lash line (the shadow cast by the eyelashes) should be your single darkest line in the entire eye area—this is the focal-point sharpness anchor. Work at light-to-medium pressure; the pupil and shadow are value anchors, not flat fills.

COLORS ● PC947 Dark Umber ● PC924 Crimson Red

✦ *The pupil shadow structure is the skeleton of the eye's entire luminosity effect. If this shadow is flat or one solid dark tone, the eye will never read as a living sphere catching light, no matter how bright the highlights become. The shadow MUST show the iris as a sphere turning away from light—that curvature is what makes reflected highlights read as light bouncing off a real surface, not a graphic element. If you're uncertain, look at the reference and see exactly where the lid shadow sits on the iris sphere; match that placement precisely.*

03 Step 3: Iris Optical Mixing and Radial Structure (Building Life)

Both irises—full iris rendering with optical color mixing

Radial strokes from pupil outward; thin, overlapping layers; light-to-medium pressure throughout; multiple hues building optically, never pre-mixing or scrubbing dense.

Light to Medium pressure

The iris is not a flat color but a sphere with radial structure emanating from the pupil. Build the iris in radial strokes (thin lines radiating outward from the pupil toward the iris edge), using multiple hues layered at light-to-medium pressure so each color remains visible and optically mixes with the layers beneath (this is the prismatic layering that keeps eyes luminous, not muddy). Start with light PC934 Lavender in the shadow zone (upper iris, under the lid shadow), then place warm PC1092 Nectar or PC939 Peach in the lit zone (lower iris, in the direction of light). Layer PC1060 20% Cool Grey and thin touches of PC924 Crimson Red in radial passes to create depth, iris texture, and the illusion of subtle patterns and vessel lines. Work at light-to-medium pressure, stroking from pupil outward and stopping short of the iris edge—let the next layer carry the boundary. Leave tiny dots of unrendered paper in the lit iris zone; these white flecks read as glossiness and life before the formal highlight arrives. The iris should read as a local color (the baby's eye color, warm with cool undertones) AND as a three-dimensional sphere turning in light.

COLORS ● PC934 Lavender ● PC1092 Nectar ● PC939 Peach
● PC1060 20% Cool Grey ● PC924 Crimson Red

✦ *The artist's note says eyes need 细节和神 (detail and spirit). That spirit comes from the radial structure—each spoke from the pupil is a micro-structure that makes the iris read as a real, dimensional surface with depth and life, not a flat painted disc. Flat irises look vacant and dead, even if perfectly colored. If you scrub the iris in dense and circular (a common amateur approach), you obliterate the radial flow and the eye goes blank. Stroke from pupil outward; trust that the thin overlapping layers will optically mix into a saturated, living color. This is harder than scrubbing but produces the 神 (spirit) the artist requested.*

04 Step 4: Sclera, Specular Highlight, and Upper Lash Definition (Eye Completion)

White of the eye (sclera), eye highlight, upper and lower lash lines

Light glaze of cool grey across sclera; warmer tone in shadow zone of sclera; sharp upper lash line in dark umber; soft, diffuse lower lash hint; single, precise, small highlight point in white or cream.

Light to Medium pressure

The sclera (white of the eye) is never pure white—lay in a very light, cool tone (PC1060 20% Cool Grey, almost invisible) across the entire white of the eye, then add a warmer tone (PC1050 10% Warm Grey) in the shadowed zone (upper sclera under the lid) to create subtle form. This keeps the eye from glowing unnaturally white and reads as a real, turned surface. The upper lash line is the focal-point definition—deepen PC947 Dark Umber along the upper lid margin to create the sharpest, darkest edge in the entire eye area; this reads as both the lid structure and the lash shadows. The lower lash is softer and more diffuse; hint at it with a light touch, but do NOT mirror the upper line's sharpness. Place a single, clean highlight (PC938 White or PC914 Cream, very small) at the specular point—for soft frontal light on an infant, this sits slightly off-center in the iris, in the lit zone, where light actually bounces off the moist eyeball surface. This one bright point is what makes the eye alive; everything else is supporting structure. Work at light-to-medium pressure on the sclera and lash, light pressure on the highlight (a sharp point, not a smear).

COLORS ☒ PC1060 20% Cool Grey ☒ PC1050 10% Warm Grey ☒ PC947 Dark Umber
☒ PC938 White ☒ PC914 Cream

✦ *The upper lash line is the ONLY hard edge you'll use in the eye. The lower lid, the iris edge, the sclera boundary—all soft and integrated. The upper line is sharp because that's where the lid is a crisp edge and light catches it; the lower lid curves away into shadow, so it dissolves. If you make both lids equally sharp, the eye looks alien and over-defined. The highlight must be small and clean—one point of true paper white or cream—not a smear or soft glow. A smear looks like a wet artifact; a precise point looks like light bouncing off a sphere. This small point is what reads as 'real eye' to the viewer.*

05 Step 5: Base Warm Skin Tone Layer - Full Face (Color Foundation)

Entire face and neck—establishing unified warm local color

Light-pressure circular strokes and soft directional hatching across the full face in thin, overlapping layers; build from lightest tone (Nectar) to warmer accents (Salmon Pink), maintaining even coverage.

Light pressure

Lay down a warm, light overall tone across the entire face, neck, and visible skin to establish the dominant local color and unify all future layers. This is the optical mixer that all cooler and warmer accents will sit over—if it's blotchy or sectioned, the whole face will read patchy. Work at light pressure with circular or soft directional strokes, keeping coverage even. Build in thin layers: first PC1092 Nectar (the dominant warm peachy-tan) across everything at light pressure, then light touches of PC1080 Beige Sienna on the warmest zones (cheeks, nose tip, forehead catch) to establish mid-tone warmth, then a whisper of PC1001 Salmon Pink on the cheeks and around the nose to hint at the delicate flush that infant skin naturally carries. Leave the underside of the nose, ear lobes, and deep transition zones slightly lighter at this stage—you'll deepen those selectively in later passes. This base pass is the foundation; avoid heavy pressure and avoid rendering individual areas to completion. The goal is even, light coverage across the ENTIRE face as one unified mass.

COLORS



PC1092 Nectar



PC1080 Beige Sienna



PC1001 Salmon Pink

✦ *Build the skin in FULL-FACE passes at light pressure first, THEN deepen and add local accent only after the base is even. If you finish one cheek before moving on, you'll create an island of color and the face will look sectioned and amateur. Infants' skin especially cannot tolerate heavy early pressure; it reads thin and delicate in the photo. Treat it that way: multiple light passes across the entire face, not one 'finished' area at a time. This is the discipline that separates professional rendering from amateur blotchiness.*

06 Step 6: Mid-Tone Skin Modeling and Form Building (Dimensional Structure)

Cheeks, nose, forehead, jaw—establishing three-dimensional form through value and color

Light-to-medium pressure; layer warm mid-tones over the base, following the contours of the face; use directional strokes that follow form turning; maintain soft edges and gradual value transitions.

Light to Medium pressure

Deepen the skin tones selectively to model the three-dimensional form, building the mid-tone zones that sit between the bright highlight areas and the shadows. On the cheekbones (the rounded form facing the light), layer PC1084 Ginger Root and touches of PC937 Tuscan Red to establish the cheek plane as a turned form; on the forehead, keep warmer and lighter to suggest the catch of frontal light. The nose tip reads lighter and warmer than the surrounding plane (subsurface scattering—light penetrates the delicate skin and exits nearby as a warm glow), so keep it warmer than the cheek and slightly highlighted. Deepen the sides of the nose with Ginger Root and light Tuscan Red, suggesting volume without harsh shadow. Work at light-to-medium pressure, allowing the warm base from Step 5 to show through each new layer; each layer should ADD depth, not obliterate what's beneath. On the jaw and chin, introduce gentle form without a hard edge or heavy shadow—the baby's soft roundness must remain readable; this is not an adult face where strong jawline definition reads as attractive; on an infant, a soft, rounded jaw reads as age-appropriate and natural.

COLORS



PC1084 Ginger Root



PC1092 Nectar



PC937 Tuscan Red



PC1018 Pink Rose

✦ *Form comes from value change, not from a separate 'shadow color.' If you think 'this area needs shadow, so I'll add dark brown,' you'll get a dark blob stuck on the face. Instead, think 'this plane turns away from light, so it will read slightly deeper (more value) while staying warm (same temperature family as the lit plane).' The cheek should be richer and deeper than the forehead, but still warm and mid-value, carrying the same peachy base. This is especially critical for soft frontal infant lighting—there's no dramatic chiaroscuro here, just gentle dimensional modeling through color richness and value.*

07 Step 7: Cool Shadow Undertones and Glaze - Very Subtle for Infant (Temperature Shift)

Shadow zones only—under nose, upper eyelid depression, soft shadow side of cheek

Very light-pressure glazes in shadow zones; soft, blended edges; work cool tones with a warm-grey shift (PC1051 20% Warm Grey) to prevent cool-shadow flatness; preserve the warm base underneath.

Light pressure

Introduce cool undertones into shadow and transition zones to create depth and to shift the receiving-shadow planes away from the light temperature-wise (the opposite of the lit zones, which stay warm). A very light glaze of PC934 Lavender under the nose and around the nostril adds model and prevents that area from reading as dead or too heavy. Trace a soft cool glaze (PC1060 20% Cool Grey, extremely light) into the upper eyelid depression and the socket shadow above the eye; if the baby's head is slightly angled, add a gentle cool glaze along the away-side jaw or cheek edge. **CRITICAL FOR INFANT FACES:** keep these shadows VERY subtle and warm-tinted—this is the most common error (overshadowing). Don't let the shadow become a cool, dead zone. The glaze should barely darken the underlying warm tone; it's primarily a temperature shift, not a value drop. Work at light pressure with soft, blended edges; these shadows should feel like they're INSIDE the form, not stuck on top of it. If the reference shows soft, frontal light with minimal shadow, your shadows should be almost invisible—a whisper, not a statement.

COLORS ☒ PC934 Lavender ☐ PC1060 20% Cool Grey ☐ PC1051 20% Warm Grey

✦ *Baby faces under soft light don't have pronounced shadows. If you start rendering them as dark shapes (common in adult portraiture), you've abandoned the reference and are drawing an imaginary dramatic version. Keep your eye on the actual photo: if the shadow is subtle there, keep it subtle here. The most common failure is overcorrecting 'flat' infant faces by pushing shadows darker—this is exactly wrong and produces heavy, gloomy, unflattering results. The temptation to 'add dimension' by darkening shadows is the #1 reason infant portraits fail. Resist it completely. The cool glaze is a whisper, not a statement.*

08 Step 8: Warm Reflected Light and Transitional Glaze (Luminosity Bridge)

Edge zones between lit and shadow—cheek edge, jaw edge, ear—establishing light continuity

Light-pressure glazes along form edges; circular blending strokes to integrate reflected light; work warm pinks and salmons into transition zones between lit and shadow; preserve underlying warm base.

Light pressure

Where the lit plane transitions to shadow (the edge of the cheek, the soft shadow along the jaw, the transition at the ear), introduce a warm, slightly saturated glaze that bridges the temperature gap and reads as reflected light bouncing from the garment, ambient sources, or the surrounding light back into the shadow zone. This is what makes skin look alive and luminous rather than like a plastic model—it says 'light is bouncing around this form, not just a flat diagram of light and shadow.' Apply thin layers of PC1018 Pink Rose or PC1001 Salmon Pink along these edges, softly blended into both the lit zone and the shadow, creating a rose-tinted halo where the form turns. This is especially important on the ear (ears glow warm and semi-transparent with lots of subsurface scattering) and around the nostril flare. Work at light pressure with soft, circular blending motions; the goal is integration and luminosity, not a visible colored stripe or 'ring light' effect.

COLORS



PC1018 Pink Rose



PC1080 Beige Sienna



PC939 Peach



PC1001 Salmon Pink

✦ *Reflected light is NOT the same as a caught highlight. A highlight is a peak, a point of maximum light; reflected light is a zone where the form is turning and ambient warmth is visible all around it. The reflected light glaze is what separates a rendering that reads as living tissue from one that reads as a photograph filtered through a grey-brown veil. If you skip this step, the face will have correct anatomy but no luminosity—it will look drawn, not alive. Include it, and the face wakes up. This step is small but crucial: it's the difference between 'nice student work' and 'professional rendering.'*

09 Step 9: Cheek and Lip Saturation Accent - Building Natural Flush (Life and Circulation)

Cheeks, lips, nose tip—placing saturated color where blood is close to surface

Circular or soft directional strokes placing saturated pinks in the high-circulation zones; soft edge blending (not hard circles); focus on cheekbone, lip fullness, and nose tip; work light-to-medium pressure.

Light to Medium pressure

Layer rose and pink tones into the cheeks with light-to-medium pressure to build the natural flush that infants carry—their circulation reads prominently in the cheek and ear zones, creating visible color saturation that signals health and vitality. Apply PC1018 Pink Rose or PC1001 Salmon Pink in circular or soft directional strokes centered on the cheekbone ball, allowing the color to fade outward into the mid-tone base layer. Crucially: don't create a sharp circle (that reads doll-like and artificial); instead, blend the edge so the flush appears to emerge from the underlying skin, not sit on top of it. On the lips, place a touch of warm pink (PC1018 or PC1001, very light, since infant lips are pale and delicate) along the fullness of the lower lip to suggest the lighter, more saturated lip surface; the upper lip stays cooler and less saturated, shadowed by the mouth structure and receiving less light. On the nose tip, a light touch of PC939 Peach or PC1001 Salmon keeps it warm and glowing—this is subsurface scattering at work, and it's essential to keep infant skin reading as thin, translucent, and alive. Work at light-to-medium pressure; avoid heavy scrubbing, which muddies the color and kills the delicate quality.

COLORS

● PC1018 Pink Rose

● PC929 Pink

● PC1001 Salmon Pink

● PC939 Peach

✦ *Saturation placement is a form-modeling tool for skin. The most saturated colors (the pinks and roses) sit where blood is close to the surface and light bounces off the skin most directly (cheeks, ears, lips, nose tip). The least saturated zones (cool greys, greyed purples) are the deepest shadows or the farther receding structures. If you place saturated pink evenly across the whole face, it looks flushed or fevered—wrong. If you concentrate it at the high points, edges, and circular zones (cheeks), it reads as natural, living circulation. Infants especially have noticeable cheek flush; getting this right makes the portrait read as a healthy, happy baby.*

10 Step 10: Nose Structure and Nostril Detail (Delicate Form)

Entire nose—bridge, tip, sides, nostrils—establishing subtle three-dimensional form

Light pressure throughout; subtle value shifts following form; warm top/tip, cooler sides; very light nostril shadow with minimal nostril-rim definition; soft, integrated edges.

Light pressure

The nose is a pyramidal form with a rounded tip and two planes (left and right) that turn away from a central ridge. Build this subtle structure with value and temperature shifts, never harsh modeling. The bridge and tip read lighter and warmer (they catch the light fully), while the sides turn into mid-tone with touches of PC1084 Ginger Root or PC937 Tuscan Red to establish volume. The tip itself should glow warm—a light touch of PC939 Peach or PC1001 Salmon to emphasize subsurface scattering. The nostrils are shadowed openings; use very light PC934 Lavender or PC1060 20% Cool Grey for the nostril cavity (never dark or graphic), then a hair-line of Dark Umber at the nostril rim (never a thick line—it should look like a shadow cast by the rim, not ink). The underside of the nose is slightly cooler and less saturated than the tip, so add a whisper of cool grey. Work at light pressure throughout; the nose is small and delicate on an infant, and overmodeling will make it look sculptural and wrong. The goal is to suggest structure without rendering the nose as a separate, defined object.

COLORS



PC1080 Beige Sienna



PC1092 Nectar



PC934 Lavender



PC947 Dark Umber



PC1018 Pink Rose

✦ *The common error is making infant nostrils look like two dark holes or rendering the nose as a rigid, faceted structure like an adult's. Infants' noses are soft, round, and barely defined. If your nostrils are dark, they're wrong—lighten them by at least half a value. If your nose bridge reads as a sharp ridge, soften it. The nose should sit in the face as a gentle, warm, rounded form, barely distinct from the cheek, not a separate sculpture. When in doubt, erase and lighten—that's the infant nose correction.*

11 Step 11: Hair Rendering - Sparse, Fine, Directional (Texture Without Density)

Entire head—hairline, crown, sides—establishing sparse, fine hair texture

Light-pressure base wash in shadow zones; full-length directional strokes following hair growth, tapering pressure toward ends; minimal individual strand definition; preserve paper white in lit zones.

Light pressure

Infant hair is sparse, fine, and light; the goal is to suggest the light pattern across the mass and individual filaments, not render a dense, heavy head of hair. Rather than rendering individual strands (a common error that makes thin hair look like an adult mop), render the light pattern and suggest individual hairs only where they catch the highest highlight or are clearly visible in the reference. Start by laying in the base tone—a light wash of PC1084 Ginger Root or PC1092 Nectar in the shadow zones of the hairline and crown to establish form and direction. Then, stroke in the growth direction (stroking full-length in the actual direction of hair growth from the scalp, tapering pressure toward the ends) with slightly darker tones (touches of PC937 Tuscan Red or PC947 Dark Umber) to suggest hair texture without filling every millimeter. Leave paper white or cream in the lit zones of the hair (where light hits the crown or the baby's head turns toward light) to indicate shine and fine texture; these bright zones read as individual filaments catching light. Add a few fine individual strokes (at very light pressure, with a sharp pencil) along the hairline or over the crown only where they're clearly visible in the reference; keep these minimal—an infant's hair is often so fine and wispy that suggesting it is better than rendering it densely. Work at light pressure overall; heavy pressure will kill the delicate quality and make the hair look matted or heavy.

COLORS

● PC947 Dark Umber

● PC937 Tuscan Red

● PC1084 Ginger Root

● PC1092 Nectar

● PC939 Peach

✦ *Baby hair is a texture, not a filled area. The difference between 'baby looks bald' and 'baby has fine hair' is about suggesting the light hitting individual filaments and the soft texture of the mass, not about rendering density. Fewer, lighter strokes that follow the direction of growth read as real hair; dense coverage reads as a wig or heavy hair that doesn't match the reference. When in doubt, erase and simplify—infants' hair is one of the easiest things to overdo.*

12 Step 12: Neck Structure and Soft Chin-to-Neck Transition (Form and Integration)

Entire visible neck, jawline, chin—establishing the neck as a continuation of the head form

Light-to-medium pressure; warm base wash on front of neck; cool, soft glaze on sides and under chin; pink integration glaze along edges; soft, blended jawline-to-neck transition; warm/cool ear modeling.

Light to Medium pressure

The neck is a continuation of the head form, not a separate element, but it reads slightly cooler and less saturated in the shadows due to its turning-away nature. Establish the neck as a cylindrical form with gentle value modeling: the front of the neck (catching light) reads lighter and warmer, similar to the face base; the sides and underside read softer, with a touch of cool glaze to suggest the soft shadow that wraps under the jaw. There is a subtle soft shadow under the chin (cast by the jaw and head upon the neck) that reads cool and mid-value; for an infant, keep this extremely light and soft—the head and neck are proportionally large and rounded (no sharp jaw definition). The jawline itself should be soft and integrated into the neck, not a hard edge—infants have no sharp jaw definition; work a light blend between jaw and neck so they read as one soft, rounded form. Introduce a gentle rose glaze (PC1018 Pink Rose or PC1001 Salmon) along the front-side transition to maintain the warm, peachy quality and prevent the neck from reading isolated or grey. The ears are a special case: they glow semi-transparent and warm (lots of subsurface scattering) with a touch of PC934 Lavender in the shadow side (the back of the ear, away from light) and warm peachy-pink on the lit side (the front of the ear facing forward). Work at light-to-medium pressure, maintaining integration between all zones.

COLORS

● PC1092 Nectar

● PC1080 Beige Sienna

● PC1018 Pink Rose

● PC934 Lavender

● PC1060 20% Cool Grey

✦ *The neck is often forgotten or rendered as dead grey, which kills the unity and luminosity of the entire portrait. Treat the neck as part of the continuous form of the head; its value and temperature should sit between the face (warmer, lighter) and the garment (lighter, more neutral). If there's a sharp color change from face to neck, your neck is wrong—adjust until the transition reads as one unified head-and-neck form. A common error is making the neck too warm (matching the face exactly), which reads flat; make it slightly cooler than the face, but never grey or desaturated. That balance is the key.*

13 Step 13: Garment Rendering - Light Cream/White Fabric Structure (Simple, Supporting)

Visible garment area—neckline, collar, body of garment

Light neutral-grey base wash; subtle shadow folds with cool blue glaze; warm reflected light accent along neckline; minimal detail; soft edges throughout.

Light to Medium pressure

The garment is light-colored (white or cream) and simple; render it as a supporting role that frames and integrates with the face, not as a focal area. Rather than rendering it as pure white (which will look flat and artificial), establish it with a very light, neutral tone (PC1050 10% Warm Grey or PC1068 10% French Grey) across the garment area, then add subtle form through gentle shadow folds and a touch of warm reflected light (a whisper of PC1018 Pink Rose where the baby's skin casts warmth down onto the neckline or upper shoulder). The folds in the garment are soft and minimal since the baby is small and the clothing is fitted; suggest folds with a slightly cooler glaze (PC1023 Cloud Blue, extremely light) that sits over the base grey, creating the illusion of form without heavy shading. Leave peaks of white or cream in the brightest areas of the garment (directly lit folds, shoulder, upper chest) to indicate light and fabric highlight. The garment should read as softer, less sharp, and less finished than the face—this is the edge hierarchy at work: work the garment at medium pressure with soft edges and minimal detail, reserving the sharpest rendering for the eyes and face. Avoid heavily texturing the fabric or adding unnecessary folds; a simple, clean garment reads as more professional than an overworked one.

COLORS ☒ PC1050 10% Warm Grey ☒ PC1068 10% French Grey ☒ PC938 White
☒ PC1018 Pink Rose ☒ PC1023 Cloud Blue

✦ *The garment is NOT the focal point—the eyes are. Render the garment just enough so it reads as present, properly lit, and integrated with the neck and skin, then back away. Over-rendering the garment pulls visual attention downward and away from the face, which is a catastrophic error in portrait hierarchy. If your garment is rendered to the same level of detail and sharpness as the face, you've misjudged the focal hierarchy entirely. A simple, clean, softly-rendered garment actually strengthens the portrait by contrast.*

14 Step 14: Garment-to-Skin Edge Integration and Reflected Light Bounce (Spatial Unity)

Neckline, shoulder-to-garment edge, color bounce zones on neck and jaw

Soft glaze integration across the edge; cool reflected light from garment onto neck; warm reflected light from skin onto garment; blended, lost edges; soft, circular strokes.

Light pressure

Where the garment meets the skin, integrate the edge and establish two-way reflected light: the white/cream garment reflects a cool, desaturated light downward onto the neck and under the chin (use very light PC1060 20% Cool Grey as an undertone glaze), and simultaneously, the warm skin reflects upward onto the garment fabric near the neckline (a whisper of PC1018 Pink Rose where the garment collar touches the warm neck skin). This two-way reflection is what makes the figure read as a unified form bathed in light, not separate pieces collaged together. Soften the actual edge where garment meets skin by blending a light mid-tone across the junction—avoid any hard line unless the photo specifically shows one (it rarely does on an infant's soft neck). The edge between garment and skin should be soft and lost, with color integration as the primary unifier. The reflected light zones should be subtle and integrated, not obvious color rings. Work at light pressure with soft, blended strokes; the goal is invisible seaming, where the eye reads 'one form lit by light' rather than 'face and garment sitting separately.'

COLORS



PC1018 Pink Rose



PC1080 Beige Sienna



PC1001 Salmon Pink



PC1060 20% Cool Grey

✦ *A professional portrait has this integration; an amateur rendering stops the skin and garment at sharp edges with no communication between them. Spend time here: the garment-to-skin edge is small but worth it because it's the final visual statement about spatial three-dimensionality and environment. If the edge reads as a cut-and-paste seam, it ruins the illusion of a unified portrait. If it reads as one integrated form, it makes the whole drawing feel professional and finished.*

15 Step 15: Refined Eye Detail and Fine Lash Accents (Focal Point Precision)

Both eyes—detail refinement, individual lashes, iris micro-structure, inner eye warmth

Sharp pencil at very light pressure; individual lash strokes following natural growth; minimal iris detail lines; tiny warm caruncle accent; highlight refinement if needed.

Light pressure

Return to the eyes with a sharp pencil to refine detail and micro-structure visible in the reference. The upper lash line benefits from a few individual lash strokes (extremely light, tapering strokes that follow the natural curve of the lid and the actual lash direction visible in the photo) placed only where lashes actually separate—not across the entire lid in uniform rows, which looks fake and dense. Add a tiny dot of very light PC1092 Nectar or PC939 Peach in the lower inner corner of the eye (the caruncle—the warm inner corner of the eyelid) to suggest anatomy and add a final touch of warmth and life. Refine any iris detail that needs clarity: a hair-thin line of PC947 Dark Umber may sit between the iris and sclera to define the boundary (but make it soft, not a graphic line), and fine radial lines within the iris (if clearly visible in the reference) can be added with a sharp pencil at very light pressure. The specular highlight may be reinforced with pure PC938 White if needed, but keep it small, sharp, and positioned exactly where light actually hits. This is a refinement and precision pass, not a repainting; use very light pressure and precise, minimal strokes. The goal is to add the final details that read as 'careful observation' and 'living eye,' not to fix or over-render.

COLORS

● PC947 Dark Umber

● PC937 Tuscan Red

● PC938 White

● PC1092 Nectar

✦ *Per the artist note about 细节和神 (detail and spirit), the eyes' detail is what carries the spirit and life of the portrait. The detail you add here—the subtle caruncle, a few individual lashes where they clearly separate, the tiny radial iris lines visible in the reference—is what makes the eye feel present and alive rather than painted or generic. Less is more: a few precise strokes read as real lashes and careful observation; a dozen dense strokes read as a false fringe. The spirit comes from restraint and precision, not from density.*

16 Step 16: Edge Hierarchy and Progressive Softening (Attention Direction)

Entire drawing—selective edge sharpening and softening to establish focal hierarchy

Light-to-medium pressure blending strokes; use 50% French Grey or colorless blender to soften edges; progressive softening from focal point outward; preserve eye sharpness as anchor.

Light to Medium pressure

Establish edge hierarchy by keeping the eyes (especially the upper lash line and iris) as the sharpest, most-defined features—this is the focal point where attention should land first and last. Progressively soften edges as you move outward and away from the eyes: soften the cheek-to-background edge, soften the jawline into shadow, soften the hair-to-background edge, intentionally lose the far-side cheek plane into a warmer, hazier mid-value (rather than rendering it as a crisp, defined plane). This directs the viewer's attention to the eyes and makes the drawing feel spatially convincing rather than flattened or all-of-a-piece. Use a light blending tool (PC1072 50% French Grey, a colorless blender, or a soft tortillon) to gently soften edges by layering over them at light-to-medium pressure, smudging the boundary slightly without obliterating the underlying colors. Preserve hard edges **ONLY** at the eye—every other edge should read softer or lost by comparison. This is a subtle effect, not a major softening; the goal is to guide attention and create depth, not to erase features or make the face blurry.

COLORS ☒ PC1072 50% French Grey

✦ *Edge hierarchy is about INTENTION and ATTENTION CONTROL. If every edge in the drawing is the same sharpness, the drawing has no focal depth, no hierarchy, and no strategy—the viewer's eye doesn't know where to look and bounces around unfocused. If you put a hard edge on the jawline and a soft edge on the eyes, you've inverted the hierarchy (the opposite of professional). Make the EYES the sharpest thing in the entire drawing, and make everything else softer by comparison. This single principle—edge hierarchy—is what transforms a competent rendering into a professional one. Understand it, and apply it intentionally to every portrait you draw.*

17 Step 17: Final Highlight Accents and Peak Light (Luminosity and Dimensionality)

Forehead apex, nose bridge and tip, cheekbone peaks, eye highlights—precise peak light placement

Light pressure, surgical placement of small, sharp, bright accents; place only where reference shows peak light; work as hard value jumps, not soft glows.

Light pressure

Push the brightest zones toward a true peak highlight that reads as a hard value jump from the surrounding midtone (this corrects the common error of faces reading 'filled' rather than 'struck by light'). The forehead apex (the highest point that catches light directly) receives a small accent of very light PC914 Cream or PC1085 Peach Beige; the nose tip and bridge catch light most directly and should sit at the absolute brightest value in the entire drawing; cheekbone peaks receive a small, crisp highlight; the eye highlights are refined and sharpened as the focal-point luminosity. This is NOT a general lighten pass over the whole face; it's a surgical accent placed only where the reference shows a genuine peak light and where that light hits the form most directly (the highest, most forward-facing points). Use light pressure (PC938 White or PC914 Cream) and add only the smallest, sharpest accent at each peak—these should read as hard jumps in value (light bouncing off skin), not gradual glows. Place these accents exactly where the reference photo shows them; if the reference shows soft, modeled light with minimal peak highlights, keep the accents subtle and few; if it shows bright, direct light (which is rare for an infant portrait), the accents can be more present.

COLORS



PC938 White



PC914 Cream



PC1085 Peach Beige

♦ *Infant skin is luminous and often catches light visibly on the highest points. The peak highlights are what read as that luminosity and three-dimensionality. Without them, the face reads as glowing evenly from within (which is flat and lifeless); with them, the face reads as sunlit and three-dimensional (which is alive and convincing). Even soft, frontal infant lighting creates tiny highlights on the forehead, nose, and cheekbones—find them in the reference and place them precisely. They're small but mighty: the difference between 'looks finished' and 'looks alive.'*

18 Step 18: Burnishing, Wax Bloom Correction, and Final Pass (Material Completion)

Entire face, especially smooth skin zones—final finish and value correction

Heavy-pressure burnishing with white/cream until smooth; wax bloom removal via gentle wipe or fixative; re-deepen darks with sharp pencil at light-to-medium pressure; final integration glaze if needed.

Heavy (burnishing), then Light to Medium (darkening correction) pressure

Burnishing is the final step and is REQUIRED and non-optional. Use PC938 White or PC914 Cream at heavy/maximum pressure to burnish the smooth skin zones (forehead, cheekbones, nose, upper eyelids, lower face) until no paper texture or white flecks remain visible—this creates the smooth, painted finish that reads as polished and photorealistic. Avoid burnishing the hair or textured areas (let them stay with some tooth for a more natural, less 'plastic' quality). After burnishing, wax bloom will appear (a slight haze on the surface from wax pigment migration to the top layer); gently wipe with a soft cloth or lightly spray with fixative (optional but recommended for protection). Once the bloom clears, punch back the darks that have been lightened by burnishing—the pupil, the upper lash line, core shadows, and any deep value zones must be re-deepened by re-applying PC947 Dark Umber or PC937 Tuscan Red at light-to-medium pressure over the burnished zones. This is the 'wax bloom correction' and is absolutely necessary; burnishing raises all values mathematically, so you MUST re-deepen the darks to restore the full value range and prevent the face from reading washed out or flat. Final review: ensure the eyes read as the brightest, sharpest focal point; check that all skin reads as unified and luminous (no blotches or patchy areas—if present, add a thin glaze of warm cream or light warm grey to unify); verify that the neck and garment integration is soft and seamless; confirm that edge hierarchy is working (hard at eyes, soft elsewhere). If all checks pass, sign and the drawing is complete.

COLORS ☒ PC938 White ☒ PC914 Cream ☒ PC1050 10% Warm Grey
☒ PC947 Dark Umber ☒ PC937 Tuscan Red

✦ *The burnishing-darkening cycle is mechanical, not artistic—it's a required material correction, like priming a canvas before painting. Do NOT skip the darkening step because you're 'tired' or 'done'—you are not done until the wax bloom is corrected and the darks are punched back to their full depth. An unburnished drawing (matte, showing paper tooth) reads as unfinished, even if the color is perfect; a burnished drawing with crushed (unpunched) darks reads as washed out and flat, erasing all the three-dimensionality you worked to build. Do both parts flawlessly: burnish for smoothness, then correct the darks for depth. This final step is where amateur work and professional work separate—the difference is literally in the execution of this last pass.*